

DSC40B:
Theoretical Foundations of Data
Science II

Lecture 11: *Breadth-first-search
(BFS) in graphs: part I*

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Graph search strategies

- ▶ **How do we**
 - ▶ find a path to go from node u to node v in the graph?
 - ▶ check whether the graph is connected?
 - ▶ compute how many connected components a graph has?
- ▶ **We want a graph search strategy**
 - ▶ which is a strategy to explore the graph systematically
 - ▶ sometimes called a graph traversal strategy
- ▶ **Different graph search strategies have different properties**
 - ▶ e.g, Breadth-first search (BFS) and Depth-first search (DFS)



General high-level ideas

- ▶ At any point during a search, each node is in exactly one of three states:
 - ▶ **undiscovered**
 - ▶ **pending** (discovered, but has not finished exploring it)
 - ▶ we say that a node is “discovered” when seeing it first time, at which point its status is changed from **undiscovered** to **pending**.
 - ▶ **visited** (done with exploring all its neighbors)
- ▶ At the beginning, all nodes are **undiscovered**
- ▶ At every step,
 - ▶ the search strategy will choose the next node to visit (explore) from the list of **pending** nodes
 - ▶ if a node is “**visited**”, then all its neighbors should be in “**pending**” or “**visited**”



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- ▶ How do we decide which is the next node to visit?
 - ▶ Breadth-first search (BFS):
 - ▶ choose the ``oldest'' pending node
 - ▶ namely, the one was discovered earliest among all pending nodes
 - ▶ Depth-first search (DFS):
 - ▶ choose the “newest” pending node
 - ▶ namely, the one that was discovered last among all pending nodes
 - ▶ Both BFS and DFS can explore the entire graph, but they have different properties making them useful in different scenarios.



Breadth-first search (BFS): the algorithm



Breadth-first search

▶ BFS(G, s)

- ▶ It will perform breadth-first search in G starting from a graph node s called the **source node**.

▶ Idea:

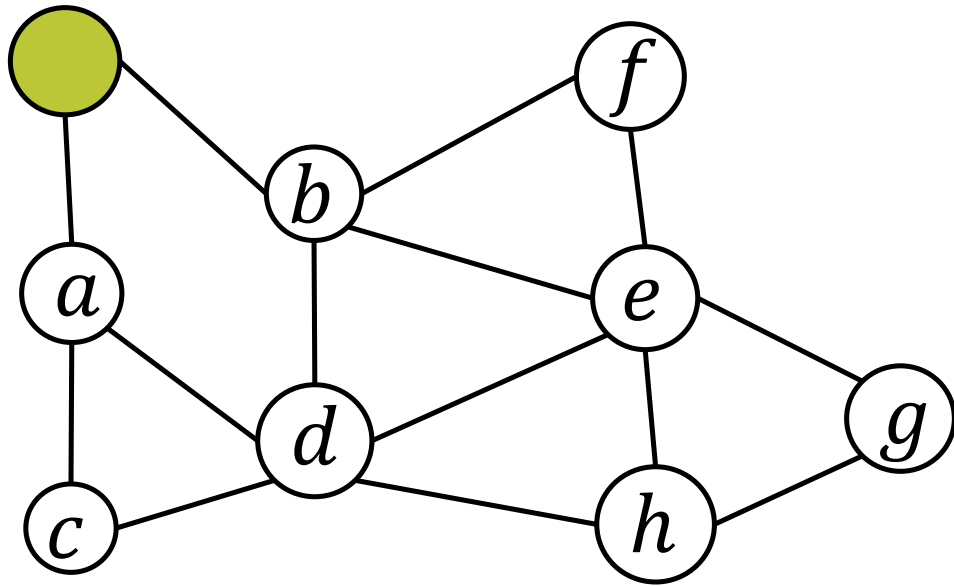
- ▶ All nodes are initialized as **undiscovered**, other than the **source node**, which is initialized as **pending** (i.e, discovered, and yet to be processed)
- ▶ At each step:
 - ▶ take the **oldest pending** node to explore
 - ▶ mark all its *undiscovered neighbors* as **pending**
 - ▶ then mark this node to be **visited**
- ▶ Repeat till there is no more **pending** nodes to explore

Convention:

In this class, neighbors are produced in sorted order. (In general, depending on your implementation, they don't have to be.)



Example



undiscovered

pending

visited



How to implement the idea?

- ▶ Recall: the key to BFS is at any moment, it will choose **the oldest pending node** to explore
- ▶ Need to maintain pending nodes:
- ▶ Need to maintain status:



How to implement the idea?

- ▶ Recall: the key to BFS is at any moment, it will choose **the oldest pending node** to explore
- ▶ Need to maintain pending nodes:
 - ▶ Need a **FIFO** (first-in first-out) data structure, which is a standard **'queue'** data structure
 - ▶ A queue data structure can support the following in $\Theta(1)$ time:
 - ▶ $Q.Enqueue(a)$: it adds a new element to the end of the current queue
 - ▶ $b = Q.Dequeue()$: it returns the element b at the beginning of the current queue.
- ▶ Need to maintain status:



How to implement the idea?

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 - ▶ A queue data structure can support the following in $\Theta(1)$ time:
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 - ▶ `b = Q.Dequeue()`: it returns the element *b* at the beginning of the current queue.
- ▶ Need to maintain status:
 - ▶ we can use an array to store status if all nodes are indexed from 0 to $n - 1$
 - ▶ or we can use a hash table (e.g, **dict** from python) to store it



Pseudocode of BFS

```
BFS( $G, s$ )  
  /* perform BFS starting from source node  $s \in V$  in graph  $G = (V, E)$  */  
  1 for each node  $v \in V$  do  
  2   |  $v.status = \text{'undiscovered'}$ ;  
  3 end  
  4  $s.status = \text{'pending'}$ ;  
  5  $Q.init()$  /* initialize  $Q$  to be an empty queue */  
  6  $Q.Enqueue(s)$ ;  
  7 while  $len(Q) > 0$  do  
  8   |  $u = Q.Dequeue()$ ;  
  9   | for each neighbor  $v$  of  $u$  do  
 10    |   | if  $v.status = \text{'undiscovered'}$  then  
 11    |   |   |  $v.status = \text{'pending'}$ ;  
 12    |   |   |  $Q.Enqueue(v)$ ;  
 13    |   | end  
 14    | end  
 15    |  $u.status = \text{'visited'}$ ;  
 16 end
```



Implementation of BFS in python

- ▶ To get the standard `'queue'` data structure
 - ▶ In python, we need to use `deque`
 - ▶ `from collections import deque` (“deck”).
 - ▶ `.popleft()`, `.pop()`, `.append()`
 - ▶ `list` doesn't have right time complexity!
 - ▶ `import queue` isn't what you want!
- ▶ To maintain `'status'` of nodes
 - ▶ we can use a hash table (e.g, `dict` from python) to store it



Python code for BFS

```
from collections import deque

def bfs(graph, source):
    """Start a BFS at `source`."""
    status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}
    status[source] = 'pending'
    pending = deque([source])

    # while there are still pending nodes
    while pending:
        u = pending.popleft()
        for v in graph.neighbors(u):
            # explore edge (u,v)
            if status[v] == 'undiscovered':
                status[v] = 'pending'
                # append to right
                pending.append(v)
        status[u] = 'visited'
```



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                # append to right
                pending.append(v)
        status[u] = 'visited'
```

Conventions:

All nodes in
graph.neighbors(u) are
sorted in increasing
(alphabetical) orders



Remarks

- ▶ The same algorithm works for both undirected and directed graphs
- ▶ Claim:
 - ▶ $\text{BFS}(G, s)$ will visit exactly the set of nodes that are reachable from the source s in the graph G
 - ▶ Why?



Remarks

- ▶ The same algorithm works for both undirected and directed graphs
- ▶ Claim:
 - ▶ $\text{BFS}(G, s)$ will visit exactly the set of nodes that are reachable from the source s in the graph G
 - ▶ Why?
- ▶ Hence some nodes may not be visited in the end,
 - ▶ and these are the nodes not reachable from source s
- ▶ Can be used to help answer questions such as:
 - ▶ Is an input undirected graph connected?
 - ▶ Is there a path from u to v ?



Full BFS and analysis



-
- ▶ Note that $\text{BFS}(G, s)$ only visits nodes reachable from s
 - ▶ So if G is disconnected, then it will not visit all nodes
 - ▶ How to explore all nodes?



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- ▶ Note that $\text{BFS}(G, s)$ only visits nodes reachable from s
 - ▶ So if G is disconnected, then it will not visit all nodes
 - ▶ How to explore all nodes?
 - ▶ ``Re-start'' from an undiscovered node, till all nodes are discovered
 - ▶ Will need to call $\text{BFS}()$ potentially multiple times, but need to maintain and pass status between calls



Full-BFS to visit all nodes

- ▶ Modify BFS() to accept statuses as well:

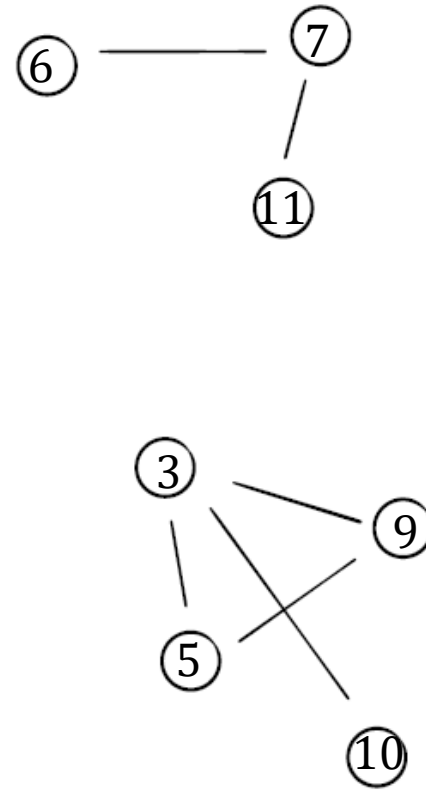
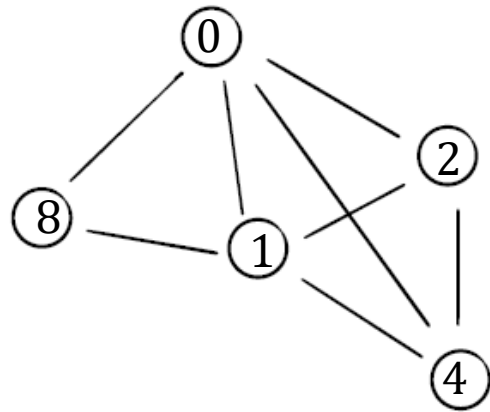
```
def bfs(graph, source, status=None):  
    """Start a BFS at `source`."""  
    if status is None:  
        status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}  
    # ...
```

- ▶ Full-BFS() procedure to visit all nodes

```
def full_bfs(graph):  
    status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}  
    for node in graph.nodes:  
        if status[node] == 'undiscovered':  
            bfs(graph, node, status)
```



Example



Observation

- ▶ If the input is an undirected graph with k components
 - ▶ then line 5 of the `full_bfs()` algorithm (namely, calling `bfs`) will be executed exactly k times.

```
1  def full_bfs(graph):  
2      status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}  
3      for node in graph.nodes:  
4          if status[node] == 'undiscovered'  
5              bfs(graph, node, status)
```



Time complexity analysis

- ▶ Analyzing full-BFS is conceptually easier than BFS
 - ▶ We can use a global argument to count the operations
- ▶ Note that time complexity on full-BFS obviously will be upper-bound for the time complexity of BFS



Overall algorithms

```
def full_bfs(graph):
    status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}
    for node in graph.nodes:
        if status[node] == 'undiscovered':
            bfs(graph, node, status)
```

```
def bfs(graph, source, status=None):
    """Start a BFS at `source`."""
    if status is None:
        status = {node: 'undiscovered' for node in graph.nodes}
    status[source] = 'pending'
    pending = deque([source])

    # while there are still pending nodes
    while pending:
        u = pending.popleft()
        for v in graph.neighbors(u):
            # explore edge (u,v)
            if status[v] == 'undiscovered':
                status[v] = 'pending'
                # append to right
                pending.append(v)
        status[u] = 'visited'
```


Time complexity for full-BFS

- ▶ Each node can be added to the queue **exactly once**
- ▶ Each edge will be explored **exactly**



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 - ▶ **twice** if the input is a undirected graph
 - ▶ **once** if the input is a directed graph
- ▶ Initializing status takes $\Theta(|V|)$ time at the beginning



Time complexity for full-BFS

- ▶ Each node can be added to the queue **exactly once**
- ▶ Each edge will be explored **exactly**
 - ▶ **twice** if the input is a undirected graph
 - ▶ **once** if the input is a directed graph
- ▶ Initializing status takes $\Theta(|V|)$ time at the beginning
- ▶ Hence overall:
 - ▶ Time complexity of full-BFS $\Theta(|V| + |E|)$
 - ▶ If $|V| < |E|$, then the time is $\Theta(|E|)$
 - ▶ If $|V| \geq |E|$, then the time is $\Theta(|V|)$



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- ▶ As a graph traversal strategy (namely we want to have a way to systematically visit all nodes in the graph)
 - ▶ The time complexity is **optimal**
 - ▶ as $|V| + |E|$ is the size needed to even represent input graph.



-
- ▶ As a graph traversal strategy (namely we want to have a way to systematically visit all nodes in the graph)
 - ▶ The time complexity is **optimal**
 - ▶ as $|V| + |E|$ is the size needed to even represent input graph.
 - ▶ If we know $|E| = O(|V|)$, then BFS takes $\Theta(|V|)$ time
 - ▶ If the graph is a complete graph, then BFS takes _____



Time complexity for BFS

- ▶ Only for $\text{BFS}(G, s)$

- ▶ Time complexity is $\Theta(|V| + m_s)$ where $m_s = \text{\#edges in the component of } G \text{ containing } s$
- ▶ Note that $m_s = O(|E|)$,
- ▶ Hence the time complexity for BFS is $O(|V| + |E|)$.



FIN

